

Cold-water hunter

A big, speedy predator, the giant Pacific octopus thrives in the cold, oxygen-rich waters around the northern rim of the Pacific Ocean, mostly in seas that are rarely deeper than 1,640 ft (500 m). The octopus grabs prey with its arms, then uses its beak to inject venom into the prey. This immobilizes the prey and softens its flesh, which the octopus then can lick out with its rasping tongue.

Octopus nursery

Each female octopus lays up to 100,000 eggs in an underwater cave or crevice. She guards the eggs, which hang in clutches, until they hatch about six months later and she dies. The tiny hatchlings then spend about two months drifting among the ocean's plankton, before descending to the seabed, where they develop into adult shape and size.



NORTH
AMERICA

CANADA

USA

Northern range

Furthest north, most giant octopuses live in shallower waters. Many live in coastal reefs and some may even drift into the intertidal zone by the shore.

Fleshy body

The thick, wrinkly skin of a giant Pacific octopus covers a soft, fleshy body that can squeeze through the smallest gaps. This is useful for catching prey hiding in crevices or escaping enemies on a rocky reef.

Accidental catch

In the rich fishing waters of the northeast Pacific, giant Pacific octopuses risk being caught in nets cast for cod and flatfish. It is the octopus species most commonly landed as a bycatch here.

Strong arms

Octopuses have eight arms that carry two rows of large suckers for gripping prey. Each arm can have more than 500 suckers in total.

**A GIANT
PACIFIC
OCTOPUS
CAN WEIGH
400 LB
(180 KG)
AND ITS
LONG ARMS
CAN SPAN
UP TO
20 FT (6 M)**



PACIFIC OCEAN